

Albus Forge — Check-in 1

Battle of the Coasts · Hour 12 · 13 Sep 2026 · Track: Deep Tech / Physical AI

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One question in. Cart, enclosure, firmware and dashboard out. Albus Forge turns a plain-language request ("tell me when my fridge gets warm") into a real parts cart, a 3D-printable enclosure, working firmware and a cloud dashboard. All of it is generated from a single curated part registry.

1. Goals for this check-in

This first 12 hours built the ground floor: everything the product runs on, in the right order, so later check-ins add features instead of fighting infrastructure.

Goal	Status	Evidence
Working infrastructure, all in Terraform	✅ Done	Three GCP projects, staging and prod environments applied, 0 drift on <code>terraform plan</code>
First iteration of the front end	✅ Live	Portal deployed to <code>staging.albusforge.ai</code> and <code>albusforge.ai</code>
Tests and quality gates in place	✅ Done	152 web tests, 25 deploy-script tests, 3 CI jobs, independent review of every PR
Automated delivery	✅ Proven	A merge that changes the web app reaches staging with no human involved. Prod is promoted by hand.

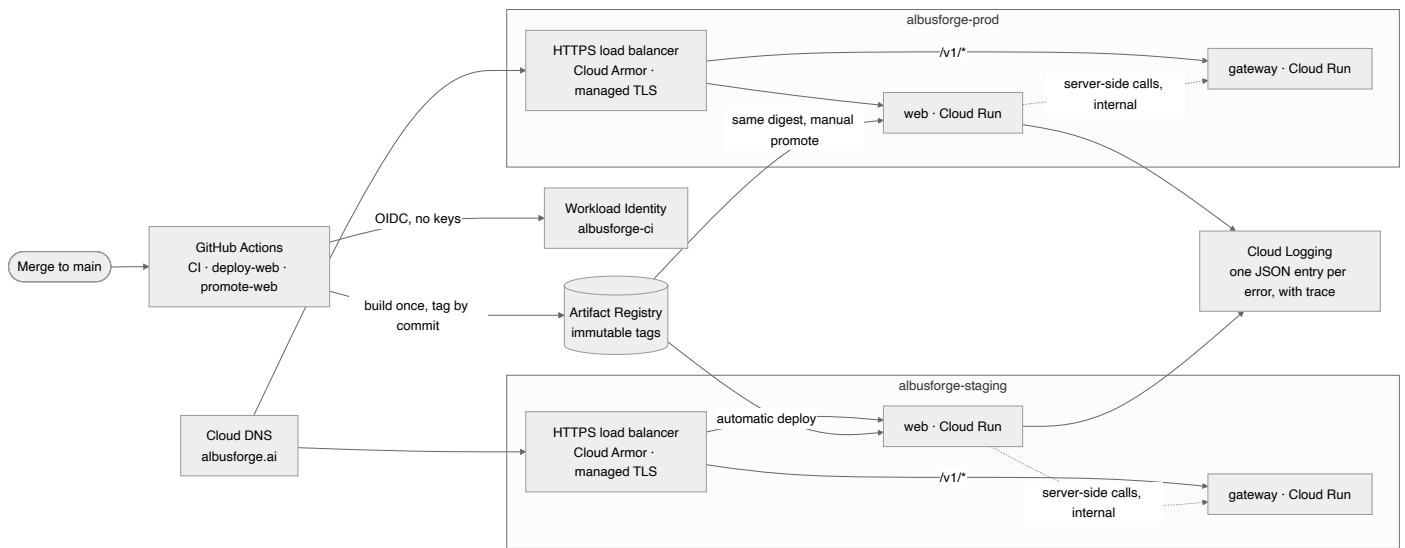
2. Where it runs

Code: github.com/guitarpastdusk/albusforge (public), trunk-based on `main`

Cloud: Google Cloud, region `us-central1`, in three isolated projects

Project	Role	Public endpoint
<code>albusforge-ci</code>	Terraform state, container registry, GitHub identity trust	none
<code>albusforge-staging</code>	Merges that change the web app land here automatically	<code>https://staging.albusforge.ai</code>
<code>albusforge-prod</code>	Only images that passed staging, promoted by hand	<code>https://albusforge.ai</code>

3. Architecture



How a request flows.

- A request enters through a **global HTTPS load balancer** protected by **Cloud Armor**. `/v1/*` goes to the API gateway, and everything else goes to the **Next.js portal**. Tenant subdomains (`acme.albusforge.ai`) route the same way.
- **Public traffic can only reach the services through the load balancer**. Their direct `run.app` URLs return 404 from the internet. Internal callers are still allowed: the portal's server-side rendering calls the gateway directly over the VPC.
- Outbound traffic leaves through **Cloud NAT**.

How code ships.

- When a merge changes the web app or its deploy files, CI builds **one deployable image for that commit** and deploys it to staging. Docs-only and Terraform-only merges don't deploy.
- A freshness check stops an older commit from overwriting a newer one.
- After a successful staging deploy, the image is tagged `staging-deployed-<commit>`.
- Prod accepts **only images carrying that tag, by exact digest**. Promotion reuses the image staging ran, and nothing is rebuilt for prod.

Design decisions are recorded as 9 ADRs in `docs/adr/`: project layout, DNS, edge routing, egress, image ownership, Terraform layout, portal routing, sign-in and tenancy.

4. The infrastructure, bottom up

1. **Bootstrap** (`infra/bootstrap`, 66 resources)
 - three projects with their APIs, and the Terraform state bucket
 - the Artifact Registry, and GitHub Workload Identity Federation bound to per-environment deployers
 - Cloud DNS for `albusforge.ai`, delegated from GoDaddy
 - a prod budget alert
 - Editor removed from the default service accounts
2. **Environments** (`infra/env`, one workspace each for staging and prod, 37 resources each)
 - a VPC with Cloud NAT and private services access
 - web and gateway on Cloud Run, each with its own service account
 - the load balancer, a Certificate Manager wildcard cert, Cloud Armor, and DNS records
3. **Delivery** (`.github/workflows`)
 - `ci`: typecheck, lint, test, build, Docker smoke test, deploy-script tests
 - `deploy-web`: automatic deploy to staging
 - `promote-web`: manual promotion to prod
4. **Application** (`apps/web`, `packages/schema`)
 - the Next.js portal and a shared Zod API contract
 - structured logging linked to Cloud Trace
 - an error page for when the gateway can't be reached

Security choices:

- no service-account keys anywhere
- deployers trust GitHub's immutable OIDC subject, pinned to the repository and owner IDs
- prod can only pull images, never build them
- both environments deploy from `main` only
- Terraform changes to a service never run while its deploy workflow could run (ADR 0005)

5. Pull requests: 14 merged by hour 12

Area	PRs	What landed
Infrastructure	#1, #5, #7, #10, #11	Terraform scaffold, remote state, least-privilege service accounts, OIDC trust fix, trace env var
Delivery	#6, #9	Staging deploy and prod promotion workflows with freshness, provenance and credential checks
Portal	#3, #12, #13, #14	App scaffold, structured logging, service-unavailable page, per-request error dedupe
Design docs	#2, #4, #8	Portal spec, API contract, sign-in and tenancy ADRs, header rules verified on staging

Every PR went through an **independent reviewer**, and every finding was fixed or answered before merge. Findings caught this way included:

- a deploy race that could roll staging back
- prod accepting images that had never run on staging
- errors from concurrent requests being silently dropped from the logs

6. Tests and verification

Layer	What runs	Result
Web unit tests	Vitest: schema parsing, API client, formatting, runtime config, logging, error UI	152 passing
Deploy-script tests	Bash, against a stubbed <code>gcloud</code> and a real git history	25 passing
CI on every PR	<code>check</code> (typecheck, lint, test, build) · <code>docker</code> (image builds and serves 5 routes) · <code>deploy-scripts</code>	Required green before merge
Terraform	<code>fmt</code> , <code>validate</code> , a reviewed plan before every apply, a no-drift plan after	0 changes pending
Live checks	Staging and prod checked in GCP after every deploy, plus browser checks of each page	Verified on both

Things verified against the real environments, not just in tests:

- TLS and routing on both domains
- trace headers preserved end to end
- one log entry per failed request, including under concurrency
- the placeholder → staging → prod image path

7. Where the build stands at hour 12

- **Live now:** landing page, docs, sign-in and pricing on both domains. Data pages (`/projects`, `/live`, `/marketplace`) render a designed "service unavailable" state, because the API gateway is still a placeholder.
- **Honest gaps:** no database yet, no real API behind `/v1`, and no AI pipeline wired in yet. This check-in was about foundations.

Next check-in (hour 24):

- Cloud SQL and the database schema
- a real gateway serving the part registry
- the first AI step: turning a plain-language ask into a structured spec